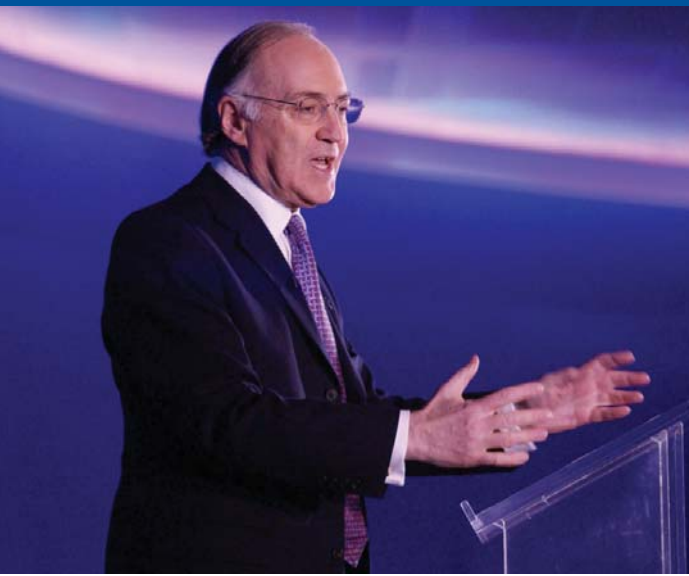


A close-up, artistic photograph of the Union Jack flag, showing the red, white, and blue stripes and the texture of the fabric. The flag is draped and folded, creating deep shadows and bright highlights.

Putting Britain First

The Conservative European Manifesto

European Elections 10th June 2004



Foreword by Rt Hon Michael Howard QC MP, Leader of the Conservative Party

The people of Europe want freedom, peace and prosperity. That was the aim of the fathers of the European Union, who wanted to heal a continent scarred by two devastating world wars. At that time, the Soviet Union threatened their very existence. It was a world in which few homes had televisions or telephones, where few people travelled by plane and where choice was strictly limited. It was a completely different world.

Today, Europe faces new challenges. This year, ten countries join the European Union, making it the largest trading bloc in the world. European companies compete for business in China, Asia and America. Its people have a global outlook. Their enemies are no longer Soviet Russia but terrorists, whose war against democracy is now being waged in their streets.

This world may be new. But the people of Europe still want the same things: freedom, peace and prosperity. And if Europe is to deliver them, it must change. The question is “how?”

Many of our jobs, and a great deal of our business, depend on trade with Europe. Working with other nations, we can solve problems that we cannot tackle successfully on our own. So Conservatives believe that Britain cannot, and should not, turn its back on Europe.

Some people believe that the best way to protect our jobs, raise our living standards and defend ourselves is to give more control to the European Union. Their vision of Europe is to continue down the same path we have followed for decades. This vision is flawed, and the evidence is plain to see.

The European Union is failing many of its people. European business is over-regulated and over-taxed, thanks in large part to the European Union. European jobs are being lost because firms

cannot compete with overseas companies operating in more flexible markets. And as Europe's institutions have grown and become more distant, so many people have lost faith in them.

The proposed new European Constitution would compound these problems. It would undermine individual Member States' ability to determine their own policies in key areas such as the economy, law and order, and asylum. Indeed, the European Union would gain most of the trappings of statehood: its own President, Foreign Minister and own legal system. Countries have constitutions: nation states make treaties with one another.

Politicians should never forget that they govern on behalf of the people. Individual parliaments, and the politicians elected to serve in them, do not own our liberties. They are there to safeguard them. They should not diminish those liberties without an explicit mandate from the British people. That is why Conservatives have always supported a referendum on the Constitution.

Tony Blair has belatedly come to his senses and now promises to give the British people a say. This is great news for Britain. It is also an admission by the Prime Minister that his effort to present the Constitution as a tidying-up exercise was phoney. Only recently he said: “If there was fundamental change here, there would be a case for a referendum. But there is not”. Now, by agreeing to a referendum, he is admitting that the Constitution means fundamental change for Britain.

Once the final text of the proposed Constitution has been agreed, we should move as quickly as possible to hold a referendum. Further delay will only prolong the uncertainty. And any referendum should be held before the Constitution is presented to Parliament. There is absolutely no point in MPs wasting months debating the Constitution if it is unacceptable to the British people.



The Prime Minister claims that there is no alternative to the Constitution. But this is simply not the case. In fact, by saying “no” the British people would be doing Europe and Britain a huge favour. Europe would be forced to confront its failings and Britain could take the lead in developing a coherent plan to modernise the EU.

As the European Union grows, its diversity of cultures, histories and traditions will grow. We believe the European Union’s institutions, and the way the Union conducts its business, should reflect that. While each nation must respect the free movement of goods, services and capital, we should tolerate diversity of views. We should not try to push every nation state into a straitjacket of uniformity. Diversity is a strength we should encourage.

So we want to create a flexible Europe. Individual nation states should be able to integrate more closely if they wish, so long as they do not force other countries to follow them. We do not all need to travel to the same destination. Europe should live and let live, flourish and let flourish.

Bold though this vision is, it is true to the spirit of our times. It confronts the world as it is, not as we would like it to be. Europe cannot be cocooned from the harsh winds of the global market. Instead, it needs to be reformed so it can rise to meet these new challenges.

We should be confident in ourselves, and have the courage to argue our case. We have much to be confident about. Britain is Europe’s largest defence power. We have the second largest economy in the European Union. And we are a net contributor to the European Union budget. While others may underestimate Britain’s strengths, Conservatives do not.

Our view is founded on clear principles from which we will not waver. We believe in a Europe that does not demand the sacrifice of independence as the price of participation. A Europe that looks outward. A made-to-measure Europe that accommodates differences.

This vision will deliver what British people want from Europe: freedom, stability, and prosperity. It will put Britain first.



Michael Howard



Foreword by Jonathan Evans MEP, Leader of the Conservative MEPs

British people want to be part of the European Union, but we want it to be more democratic and more accountable. We want the EU to do less and to do it better. That is why the Conservative Party wants a New Deal for Europe.

Our vision for the future of the EU is explained in the first chapter of this Manifesto. It sets out the approach that Conservative MEPs will adopt for the next five years. In the other chapters of this Manifesto, we address in more detail those areas of policy where the European Parliament will face crucial choices in its next term.

Many of the decisions that the European Parliament takes will have a direct impact on the daily lives of British citizens, British taxpayers, British businesses, British farmers and British fishermen.

That is why it is so important that as many Conservative MEPs as possible are elected to the European Parliament. Only the Conservatives can be trusted to put Britain first in Europe. Promoting British interests is our top priority in the European Parliament.

Our approach is very different from that of either Labour or Liberal Democrat MEPs. They see themselves as Europe's representatives in Britain. Their record shows they are determined to vote for still more EU powers and still more EU control.

As the largest British political force in the European Parliament, the record of Conservative MEPs shows our ability and determination to deliver for Britain.

We will work to make Europe a better place to do business, with less red tape and more opportunities for British firms to grow and create jobs.

We will make certain that the voices of British farmers and fishermen are heard loud and clear in Brussels. We are committed to radical reform of the Common Agricultural Policy and to a new policy on fishing that will end the shambles of the Common Fisheries Policy.

We will continue to fight fraud, waste and maladministration in the EU and to demand much better value for money for British taxpayers.

We will work to ensure practical protection for the natural environment and a high standard of animal welfare throughout Europe.

We will press for co-operation but resist harmonisation in Europe as we seek better solutions on immigration, asylum, policing and defence.

And we will be proud to represent the interests of the people of Gibraltar in the European Parliament.

Conservatives in the European Parliament have worked hard for the past five years to deliver on our 1999 election pledge to be in Europe, but not run by Europe. In the next five years we will continue to do so – ensuring that above all else we put Britain first.

A handwritten signature in black ink, which appears to read 'Jonathan Evans'.



PUTTING BRITAIN FIRST – THE CONSERVATIVE VISION

The Conservative Way

Over the last half century, the European Union has achieved a great deal. It has been a force for peace and stability. It has created a Single Market of over 455 million people. These are considerable achievements. But the European Union needs to change if it is to meet the challenges of a new century. Conservatives want to be at the forefront of that change.

Enlargement and the debate about the new European Constitution offer a unique opportunity to recast Europe in the image of the twenty first century: to build a Europe based on co-operation and not on coercion. A competitive, free market and flexible European Union will give individual Member States the space to be different and room to breathe. People want smaller and less intrusive government just as much at the European level as they do at the national level.

That is why Conservatives do not support the federalists' vision. Conservatives believe that Britain should remain an independent state and that our country should not be submerged into a single European state. In a world of increasing change and uncertainty, people need to feel a sense of solidarity with the institutions which serve them. And the institution that is best able to provide that sense of solidarity and security is the nation state.

Labour – Failure of Leadership, Failure of Vision

In 1994 Tony Blair told the Labour Party Conference that: "Under my leadership, I will never allow this country to be isolated in Europe". Of course, no one ever wants to be isolated in Europe but it is sometimes necessary if you are to put Britain's interests first.

Tony Blair's Government used to oppose a European Constitution. It used to oppose a legally binding Charter of Fundamental Rights. It promised to keep home affairs matters – asylum, immigration and criminal law – intergovernmental, not subject to the European Commission. Labour have gone back on all of these promises. Far from showing leadership in Europe, Tony Blair has chosen to follow the agenda set by others. He has been desperate to please everyone – to be all things to all men.

Just as Labour have failed to influence how the EU's institutions have developed, they have failed to drive through badly needed deregulation in Europe. Labour MEPs have consistently voted for more EU regulation and more red tape, at times even rebelling against their own Government.

Labour's support for the proposed European Constitution is yet another example of their failure to put Britain first. It demonstrates that they have no idea about the changes Europe needs to make if it is to face the challenges of the twenty first century. The Constitution would mean greater centralisation, more regulation and less flexibility.

In his desire never to be isolated in Europe, Tony Blair has failed to put Britain first. Labour have let people down.

Liberal Democrats – Brussels' Yes Men

No other party in Britain is so keen to see Brussels have more power over Britain as the Liberal Democrats.

The Liberal Democrats would scrap the pound. They enthusiastically back the proposed European Constitution. They want to abolish Britain's seat on the UN Security Council – instead we would be represented there by the EU. They want to abolish Britain's veto in foreign affairs. They even want to abolish Britain's veto on tax harmonisation, despite the huge damage this could do to our competitiveness, as well as setting up a new Euro tax.



Quite simply, the Liberal Democrat programme is to abolish Britain's independence and create in its place a federal European state run from Brussels.

The Nationalists – weakening Scotland and Wales' voices in Europe

The SNP and Plaid Cymru want to split Scotland and Wales from the rest of the United Kingdom. This would leave the Scots and Welsh weakened in Europe. By acting together, we can ensure that every part of the United Kingdom has its voice heard in Europe. While the SNP support our policy of restoring our fisheries to national control, they fail to understand that a united Britain is far better placed to deliver it than an isolated Scotland.

The European Constitution

Conservatives oppose the Constitution. We disagree with many of its provisions but we also oppose the very idea of an EU constitution. Countries have constitutions – nation states make treaties with one another.

The Constitution marks a profound change in the way Europe works – shifting more power from the individual nation states to Brussels.

The Constitution will be bad for jobs and our economy

- The Constitution gives the EU powers to impose costly new regulations on businesses in Britain. Gordon Brown admits that over 50% of regulations imposed on British business already come from Brussels.
- As part of the EU Constitution, the so-called Charter of Fundamental Rights will give the European Court of Justice large powers to interfere with our employment practices, replacing them with the kind of industrial relations we see in France and damaging further the hard-won flexibility that has let British business succeed on the world stage.

The Constitution will give the EU control over asylum and immigration

- The Constitution would set up "a common European asylum system" and a "common immigration policy". It would end Member States' right of veto over EU immigration and asylum policy.
- The European Court of Justice would be given new powers over how EU Member States deal with asylum seekers and it would become impossible for us to change international treaties in order to adapt international asylum rules to modern circumstances.

The Constitution will give the EU greater control over criminal justice and our courts.

- Under the Constitution, the EU would increasingly harmonise legal procedures in criminal cases. It would increasingly control the rights of criminals and how evidence could be used against them. The Government have already breached one of their so-called 'red lines' and agreed that the EU would decide people's rights on arrest, with no national vetoes.

- It would increasingly give the EU power to decide on the definitions of certain crimes. The EU could set minimum prison sentences.

The Case for a Referendum

It is for these reasons that Conservatives have always supported a referendum on the proposed new European Constitution. Conservatives trust the people to have their say.

Last year Tony Blair took the view that "we do not need a referendum ... whatever constitution comes out". Thankfully he has come to his senses and decided to give the British people a say on whether we sign up to the Constitution.



Labour's reluctant acceptance of a referendum has made clear just how significant a change the Constitution really is. Only recently Tony Blair was arguing that "If there was fundamental change here, there would be a case for a referendum. But there is not." In supporting a referendum, he has in effect admitted that the Constitution would indeed mean a "fundamental change".

The question put to the British people must be clear and simple. This is not a debate about Europe, in or out. This is a debate about the EU Constitution, and the question can and should be straightforward: whether Britain signs up to the European Constitution or not.

Once the final text of the proposed Constitution has been agreed we should move quickly to hold a referendum. There is no case for further delay and there is no point in MPs wasting months talking about the Constitution if it is unacceptable to the British people. An early referendum would end uncertainty.

A Programme for a Twenty First Century Europe

People worry that they have no say over what happens in Europe and that power inexorably passes from Britain to Brussels. Conservatives want an EU that actually works to deliver what people want from it and that people feel they have some control over.

The Conservative Party has a clear agenda for a twenty first century Europe. A Conservative victory in the European elections would be a big step towards that goal.

Our alternative programme would make the EU more open, more accountable and more efficient. It would be an EU that would not try to do everything, but that would do what it does better.

1. We want to build a flexible Europe, following the precedents set by the opt-outs from the Euro and the Schengen agreement. *Enhanced co-operation* enables some Member States to go ahead with further integration, even when others do not want to do so. So countries which wanted to integrate still further could so but others would not be compelled to join them.
2. The Conservative approach will anchor national parliaments at the heart of the EU law-making and decision-making process. If, say, five or more national Parliaments object to new, or existing, European legislation on the grounds of subsidiarity or proportionality it should be withdrawn or repealed (the 'Red Card' procedure). For the first time subsidiarity would be properly enforced by bodies that have a genuine interest in seeing the principle practised. And, at least in Britain's case, a senior Minister should head UKREP (the United Kingdom's representation in Brussels) and attend COREPER (Committee of Permanent Representatives) meetings, and report back to the Commons and the Lords on a fortnightly basis. This would not require Treaty change.
3. The EU Commission should lose its monopoly right of initiative on legislation and share it with Member States. The European Parliament should have a right of repeal over European legislation.
4. The current rotating Council presidency should be reformed by establishing rotating team presidencies of, say, one year, involving big and small members, allowing the burden of chairing the Council of the European Union to be shared between members.
5. Free markets and free trade should be reaffirmed as central Treaty objectives. The *acquis communautaire* needs to be systematically reviewed so that powers which would be better administered by the nation states are returned to them.

- 
6. All EU proposals need independent cost assessments. The EU should adopt a more 'evidence-based' approach to legislation. Action should only be taken where there is clear, quantifiable evidence of the need for regulation. We need more uniform enforcement of agreed legislation, tougher penalties for rule-breakers across the EU, and 'sunset clauses' for all legislation.
 7. The EU should encourage co-operation between European countries at informal and non-governmental levels, for example between professional organisations.
 8. Defence and foreign affairs co-operation should be defined in practical organisational terms. This would allow ad hoc coalitions and pan-European action where desirable and task-specific, all within the NATO structure.
 9. Referendums on future significant constitutional Treaty changes should be compulsory in Britain.
 10. The Common Fisheries Policy is emptying our seas of fish and has utterly failed our fishermen. We will negotiate to restore local and national control over British fisheries. We will also negotiate to increase British national control over overseas aid.



COMPETITIVENESS AND ENTERPRISE

The EU is the world's biggest market-place, where 455 million people will be doing business. Given its huge opportunities, Europe should have the most dynamic and competitive economies in the world. Yet the United States economy is growing twice as fast as Europe, and China and the Pacific Rim are providing intense competition. Without a step-change in EU policy, Europe's story will be one of relative decline.

Europe's leaders often talk toughly about improving competitiveness, but words are not matched by deeds. Economic reform is proceeding slowly in some areas; in others it is non-existent. Labour ministers pay lip-service to Europe's competitiveness agenda, but their policies steadily erode the UK's competitive position through ever-increasing burdens of taxation and red tape. In Brussels, Labour MEPs are in the forefront of the pernicious quest for more and more European regulation.

The Single Market was meant to boost growth and productivity. But the nation states of the European Union are still bedevilled by rules, regulation and red tape, which significantly impede our ability to compete. That is why our economies are not as dynamic as that of the United States. That is why productivity per person is almost 20% higher in the United States than it is in the European Union, and output per hour is 15% higher. That is why over the last decade employment in the United States grew almost twice as fast as in the European Union. If we had the same record as the United States in creating jobs, 28 million more people would be in work in the European Union today.

Conservatives will continue to support the job-creating liberalisation of European markets. This could create many millions of jobs across Europe. The European Parliament must ceaselessly press the EU to create a business climate that stimulates job creation, growth, enterprise and competitiveness. That will realise our Conservative

vision of a genuine Single Market throughout Europe, providing new opportunities for British businesses to expand abroad. Increased competition is also in the interests of consumers: for them it means lower prices and better quality products and services. Conservatives will put Britain first by helping build a Europe that works better for business and better for consumers.

Conservatives are committed to a competitive Europe...

- We will work to complete and strengthen Europe's internal market. That means, for example, that we will only support new regulations that will open markets and improve competitiveness.
- We will oppose British membership of the Euro.
- We will promote flexibility in the jobs market and lead a campaign for the preservation of Britain's right to an opt-out from the European Working Time Directive for all employees who want it. We will also keep up our opposition to the Temporary Workers Directive.
- We will oppose European tax harmonisation, defend the UK's zero rates of VAT and work for sensible reform of the VAT system, in particular to address the tax problems faced by churches and charities.
- We will work for further reform of competition law, in particular the rules covering the automobile sector, to clamp down on monopolies, cartels and anti-competitive practices, in order to get a better deal for consumers.
- We will continue to reject EU efforts to impose congestion charges and tolls on all major roads in Europe, along with other measures that would undermine competitiveness in the transport sector and which, in any event, should be left to national decision making.

Air Travel: cheaper and safer

Throughout the 1980s and 1990s Conservatives led efforts to liberalise air travel in Europe. Britain now has more air passengers than any other country in Europe and, globally, is second only to the United States. The growth of budget and low-cost airlines has played an important part in this success. In the wake of the terrorist attacks on the US on 11 September 2001, Conservatives also led efforts to introduce key improvements in security while ensuring that air travel remained viable and attractive to passengers. Air passengers in Europe can look confidently to us to safeguard their interests.

Telecoms: a deregulated market.

Conservative MEPs have been at the forefront of moves to liberalise the market in telecoms in the EU since 1999. There are now fewer regulations in this sector in Europe than in the US, which shows what can be done when the right policies prevail. People in the UK now enjoy more choice and lower costs in phone calls and Internet connections as a result. The challenge now is to apply this approach across the board, to energy markets, financial services, transport and to the mutual recognition of qualifications.

...and to promoting enterprise...

- The EU must focus on the opportunities offered by new markets and technologies. Its priority should be to provide a legislative framework which assists companies in exploiting new technologies.
- The EU must promote innovation and new enterprises by making it easier for them to get started and develop.

...not just in Europe but on a global scale...

- Conservatives will promote global trade and actively support the efforts of the World Trade Organisation to remove barriers to it.
- We will support the aims of the Doha Development Round of world trade talks, which will benefit not just the EU, but the world's poorer countries as well.
- We believe that the goal of creating a single transatlantic market by 2015 is achievable and we will work to support it.

As for Labour...

- There is a wide gulf between the rhetoric of Labour ministers on competitiveness and the record of their Government which has steadily undermined the competitive position of the UK since 1997 with an incessant flow of new taxes and regulations.
- Labour MEPs embody the worst excesses of an outdated, pro-regulation, pro-tax Euro-socialist approach. They are at the forefront of calls for more employment legislation and for stronger European trade union rights. They have backed higher burdens on business in employing part-

time staff, voted to abolish the British Working Time Directive opt-out and supported a directive which would give trade unions greater rights to interfere in business decision making.

- Labour is committed in principle to take us into the Euro even though our country has prospered outside it. A Labour MEP has even said that European tax harmonisation is "no big deal". Yet this would mean decisions on tax being made in Brussels, not Britain, and lead to higher taxes on British companies, harming our competitiveness and destroying British jobs.

And the Liberal Democrats...

- Liberal Democrats favour joining the Euro at the earliest possible moment, and even harmonising taxes is not enough for them – they have proposed that the EU be given the power to set and levy its own taxes.

New Threats from the EU Constitution

- The EU would have the power to adopt measures to co-ordinate economic and employment policies – potentially a huge extension of EU influence.
- National vetoes could be abolished in new areas of employment and social policy (such as social security, employment conditions for non-EU citizens and redundancy provisions).
- The Charter of Fundamental Rights will mean that European judges in Luxembourg will impose rules to restrict business freedom, moving Britain to the kind of stagnant business environment too many continental countries suffer from.



FIGHTING FRAUD AND WASTE

The EU's budget is not subject to adequate accountability and control. A succession of scandals in the past decade has shown that profound and systemic weaknesses remain unchecked in the European Commission's financial and personnel management. Every year, between five and eight per cent of the EU's £65 billion budget – more than £3 billion pounds that hard-working people have paid in their taxes – goes 'missing' through mismanagement and fraud. For the past nine years the European Court of Auditors has been unable to certify the EU accounts, principally because insufficient records have been kept by the Member States to prove that the money was spent properly.

No-one has done more to expose cases of EU fraud and mismanagement than Conservative MEPs, who have highlighted the issues raised by a number of brave 'whistleblowers' and pressed relentlessly for reform. It was Conservative MEPs who organised and led the campaign to expose the scandals of the last Commission, which resigned in 1999. An enquiry of 'wise men' was then set up which recommended many far-reaching reforms.

Fraud and maladministration in the EU can be tackled if the right structures are put in place and if the political will exists to deal with the problem. Some progress has been made by implementing the majority of the 'wise men's' recommendations – for example, by changing the EU's Financial and Staff Regulations. But change has been slow and inadequate: the Prodi Commission has demonstrably failed to reform sufficiently the current confused system. The Vice-President in charge of reform, Neil Kinnock, must shoulder the blame for this. Because of his failure, cases of mismanagement and waste continue – as in the EU's statistical agency, where millions of pounds were 'looted' – and 'whistleblowers' are still not given a full hearing. Putting Britain first means ensuring British taxpayers' money is not mismanaged and wasted.

There must be proper political responsibility for tackling fraud...

- The EU needs a Commissioner with sole responsibility for budgetary control, who would oversee all those officials charged with ensuring proper accounting, tackling fraud and improving transparency.
- All Commissioners should have a cabinet member with specific responsibility for all management control issues – and they must take full political responsibility for failings within their own departments.
- OLAF, the EU's anti-fraud unit, should be fully independent, with its own staff, budget and organisational priorities, subject to a new Management Board.
- Member States must implement EU policies properly and account adequately for all expenditure on EU programmes.
- The Court of Auditors should undertake a number of programme audits for all Member States, rather than just a sample of them, and publish a detailed assessment for each. And they should be followed up in subsequent years so that progress can be measured.
- Until confidence in the EU accounting system is restored by effective reform, Conservative MEPs will refuse to sign off the Commission's accounts – and so will a future Conservative Government.

And Conservatives will press the European Commission to use best business practice...

- We want the EU's budget to give Britain value for money. We will fight to prevent the growth of the EU budget leading to tax rises for British taxpayers by keeping national contributions to the EU budget at one per cent of GDP.

The Marta Andreasen case

Conservative MEPs are recognised as the most reliable and determined opponents of fraud and waste in the EU. That is why the European Commission's Chief Accountant, Marta Andreasen, wrote to Conservative MEPs when she became frustrated that her concerns about the inadequacy of the European Commission's accounting system were not being taken seriously. Conservatives brought the issues to public attention and forced Commissioners Kinnock and Schreyer to come before Scrutiny Committees in the Parliament to answer the allegations, which turned out to be well-founded. Conservative determination has been rewarded by a long-overdue undertaking to modernise the Commission's accounting system. Its implementation is being closely monitored.

- A unit in the Commission should be set up so that employees can air complaints privately without fear of persecution or disciplinary procedures. Serious concerns should then be passed on to the EU's anti-fraud squad or the police.
- Stronger protection is needed for 'whistleblowers': the current charter must be strengthened and reformed.
- The EU Code of Good Administrative Conduct, a Conservative initiative, must be made binding on all EU institutions and officials.

As for Labour...

- In Government, Labour have continued to sign off accounts that the Court of Auditors has failed to approve – no normal business would be allowed to work in this way. Labour MEPs have refused to support 'whistleblowers' who try to expose fraud and mismanagement in the EU.
- Former Labour leader, Neil Kinnock, has been in charge of rooting out fraud and maladministration. He promised a "whistleblowers' charter", but when 'whistleblowers' came forward he had them moved from their jobs.

And the Liberal Democrats...

- They are so deeply committed to the European project that they regard EU fraud and waste and nothing more than minor distractions. When the European Commission's Chief Accountant revealed major flaws in the EU accounting system – of the kind that allowed corrupt officials in Eurostat to loot millions of pounds of public funds – the Leader of the Liberal Democrat MEPs Graham Watson described the issue as a "storm in a teacup".

New Threats from the EU Constitution

- The Constitution would introduce no significant improvements to the way in which the EU tackles fraud and maladministration. There would be no stronger European or national parliamentary scrutiny of the budget and no provision to increase the protections offered to 'whistleblowers'.



SETTING EUROPE FREE FROM RED TAPE

'Too much regulation' is one of the most common complaints that people have about the EU. Some regulation is necessary, for example to protect the rights of consumers. But all too often, EU regulations are unnecessary or disproportionate. Businesses and ordinary people in Europe have to spend too much time and money complying with EU regulations and directives. This is often more than just a nuisance; it stops entrepreneurs from developing the businesses on which new jobs depend.

Many MEPs are content to back more EU controls. Indeed, Labour and Liberal Democrat MEPs tend to be enthusiasts for more and more EU regulations. Conservatives want to turn back the tide. Unnecessary, disproportionate or outdated regulations must be scrapped. New regulations must be subject to rigorous cost assessments. We will campaign to get the European Parliament to adopt our approach and make it a key priority.

The war on EU red tape must be fought at Westminster as well as in Brussels, and we will conduct a unified campaign in both places. European legislation must not be applied in a way that hobbles Britain. Too many rules and regulations are 'gold-plated' by Whitehall and over-zealously implemented by local enforcement officers, while there is suspicion that other countries turn a blind eye to measures they do not like. Conservatives will put Britain first by cutting back the red tape that ties businesses down.

Conservatives want to turn back the tide of red tape:

- We will fight 'one-size-fits-all' legislation and harmonisation. EU directives must take full account of Europe's diversity and the circumstances of individual regions and industries.

- We will insist on 'price tags' for all new EU proposals, including parliamentary amendments. We back the scheme of regulatory impact assessments that has been proposed, insisting that these assessments are comprehensive, independent and obligatory for all EU legislation.
- We want to get rid of at least 25 per cent of all existing EU regulations and introduce 'sunset clauses' for all new regulations, so that they will expire automatically after a set period of time.
- We want the highest priority to be given to assessing the impact of EU regulations on small businesses. We will propose measures to promote and safeguard the interests of small business at EU level.

And we will provide joined-up opposition to red tape at Westminster:

- We want firm measures to stop the 'gold-plating' of EU regulations in Whitehall – for example, joint Committees of MPs and MEPs to oversee implementation and prevent the introduction of requirements that other Member States escape.
- Conservatives will champion the European Union (Deregulation) Bill, which will give British business and people an effective means of challenging the extra burdens and costs arising from the way in which European regulations are applied in the UK. It will give courts in Britain the power to strike down excessive burdens on business imposed by British civil servants.

As for Labour...

- Labour's manifesto in 2001 promised that: "We will deregulate where desirable, and regulate where necessary with as light a touch as possible." Yet the total cost of their regulations since 1997 amounted to £5.92 billion per year by 2002, according to the Institute of Directors.

- 
- Labour MEPs have consistently voted to impose ever more EU regulation on British business. They repeatedly vote with their Euro-Socialist allies for more red tape against the instructions of their own Government, as on the Temporary Workers Directive, the Working Time Directive and the Information and Consultation Directive.

And the Liberal Democrats...

- The Liberal Democrats strongly support the European Constitution including the so-called 'Charter of Fundamental Rights', which would pave the way for the European Court of Justice to impose a range of new burdens on businesses in the UK.

New Threats from the EU Constitution

- The so-called 'Charter of Fundamental Rights' would herald the imposition of more burdens on business and the granting of new powers to trade unions by the European Court of Justice.
- The EU Constitution ignores the pressing need to repeal redundant legislation, and to improve the quality of EU legislation in future. They should have been central considerations since, without change the EU cannot operate effectively and openly.



PROTECTING AND IMPROVING OUR ENVIRONMENT

Conservatives care deeply about our environment and take pride in our record of action to protect it. Some strong environmental laws are needed at an international level – for pollution knows no boundaries. Immediately after the last European Elections, Conservative MEPs negotiated successfully to secure the chairmanship of the European Parliament's Environment Committee for a Conservative MEP, who has been able to make the European Parliament take into consideration the impact of environmental regulation on people and businesses. This demonstrates the high importance we attach to safeguarding our environment for future generations.

Conservatives are determined that all EU countries should play by the rules. To be properly effective, environmental legislation must be enforced fairly and equally. So existing legislation must be applied uniformly in all EU countries, with tough penalties for those who break the rules. Those rules should be designed to work with, rather than against, businesses. Requirements should be realistic and manageable throughout the EU – the alternative is to drive industry to countries where environmental constraints are far less stringent.

Conservatives recognise that laws which are badly implemented fail people and fail the environment. When new environmental laws are introduced at a European level, the Labour Government often dithers and delays over exactly how they should be implemented in the UK. Guidance is almost always too late and too complicated. Prompt and clear decisions are needed about how EU rules are going to apply in Britain so that our measures are effective in protecting our environment and safeguarding the health of our citizens. Conservatives will put Britain first by ensuring that we have better environmental laws that are properly and fairly enforced.

Conservatives believe in practical and effective environmental legislation based on firm principles:

- *Safe food for all.* The origins of all food must be traced and clearly labelled to show production standards and in particular whether GM ingredients have been used.
- *High animal welfare standards.* Livestock welfare during transportation should be strictly policed and the ban on exporting horses for slaughter maintained. The phasing out of animal testing for cosmetics must be strictly enforced.
- *Protection of endangered species.* Tough measures to combat poaching and the illegal trade in endangered species must be high priorities.
- *Caution on Genetically Modified crops.* Any authorised planting of commercial GM crops must be accompanied by a legal framework to protect biodiversity and to clarify liability for contamination.
- *Reduction of greenhouse gases.* Realistic targets for the reduction of greenhouse gas emissions are essential, backed up by penalties for those countries not meeting them.
- *Greener, cleaner energy sources.* Research and development into green alternatives to fossil fuels is vital and subsidies should be reallocated to help achieve this essential environmental change.
- *A thriving, environmental economy.* A strong 'enviro-economy' makes good business sense, creating new markets and jobs.

Recycling:

The Waste Electrical and Electronic Equipment Directive is due to come into effect this year. It deserves full support in that it will end the practice of dumping electrical goods like washing machines, computers and televisions into landfill sites. But the Government has failed to put a system in place for dismantling and recycling these goods. So another crisis like that of the recent 'fridge mountain' is in prospect with rusting goods piling up throughout the country until arrangements are made to deal with them at taxpayers' expense.

Recycling:

The End of Life Vehicle Directive, due in 2007, will place the cost of disposing of cars sold after 2002 on the manufacturer. But it will increase the costs of disposing of older cars, which will remain the responsibility of their owners. The Government has failed to put in place recycling procedures for these old cars and so the number of abandoned cars littering the streets can be expected to increase significantly – with the cost of their collection and removal being borne by the taxpayer.

As for Labour...

- The Labour Government signed up to an EU regulation on the safe disposal of old fridges, without estimating the cost or providing the means to implement it successfully. As a result, mountains of old fridges appeared around the country and local councils were left with huge bills for removing them. Government incompetence inflicted great damage on the environment and on the council taxpayer.
- Labour MEPs have repeatedly signed up to EU environment laws without giving any thought to how they will be applied in practice or to the potential costs.

And the Liberal Democrats...

- The Liberal Democrats refuse to speak out against the EU's environmental policy mistakes or against badly thought out EU legislation. Their commitment to legislation, regardless of cost or practicality – such as their attempted extension of the costly Bathing Waters Directive to streams used for kayaking – fails Britain and fails the environment.

New Threats from the EU Constitution:

- The environment would be classified as a 'shared competence' between the EU and Member States, so Britain would only be able to pass new environmental laws where the EU decided not to do so.
- National vetoes could be removed over areas such as planning, water management and land management.
- The EU would formally acquire a role in most aspects of energy policy for the first time – with no national vetoes.



AGRICULTURE AND FISHING

The EU's Common Policies on Agriculture and Fisheries fail our farmers, fishermen, consumers and the environment. That is now widely agreed. The only beneficiaries of existing arrangements are a few, narrow vested interests. We have pressed for fundamental and radical change.

The Common Agricultural Policy (CAP) has become notorious because of its artificially high prices for consumers, damaging consequences for third-world producers, low incomes for farmers and endless red tape. Conservatives have long campaigned for CAP reform that would decentralise decision-making. Such reform is now beginning to take place. Breaking the link between farm subsidies and production provides a golden opportunity for our farmers to compete in the market, while receiving support for the environmental benefits they provide.

Britain once had Europe's richest fishing grounds, accounting for three-quarters of total EU fish stocks. The catastrophic effects of the Common Fisheries Policy (CFP) have changed all that: disappearing fish stocks, declining fleets, lost jobs, emergency closures and draconian conservation measures are now the main features of an EU fisheries policy that has failed. National and local control over our waters must now be restored to give British fishermen a fair deal. Conservatives will put Britain first by fighting for farming and fishing policies that suit Britain's farmers and fishermen.

We want to see CAP reform go further to give British farmers the freedom to produce for the world marketplace:

- We will press for the full decoupling of subsidy from production across the whole of Europe and for an end to trade-distorting export subsidies in all appropriate cases. The

appalling waste of £600 million of taxpayers' money in subsidising tobacco production will be our first target.

- We will support the proposed new Single Farm Payment and will press for it to be implemented with a minimum of bureaucracy and red tape.
- We will demand new mechanisms to stop the 'gold-plating' of Brussels legislation by British Government officials in DEFRA.
- We will press for an improved border control regime for food imports, especially meat imports from third countries. Proper controls could have averted the 2001 Foot and Mouth outbreak.
- We will also investigate ways of ensuring that meat imports into this country come from animals raised under the same health and welfare standards as apply here.
- We will campaign for the clear labelling of produce to show both its country of origin and its method of production.
- We want to ensure that EU rules on animal welfare are enforced uniformly throughout the EU and will look to improve the protection of animals during transport.

And we want an end to the damaging aspects of the CFP:

- The CFP must go in its existing form. An incoming Conservative Government will negotiate to restore national and local control over British fishing grounds, with sensible bilateral arrangements and recognition of the historic rights of other nations.



- We will work with commercial fishermen, recreational anglers, and environmentalists to draw up a national management scheme for UK fisheries based on sound science, which will sustain stocks and support a prosperous fishing industry.
- We will demand a ban on fishing methods which lead to the discard of dead fish or the destruction of thousands of dolphins and porpoises. We will work for an extension of the EU Habitats Directive to give the same protection to marine sites as is given to birds and mammals.

As for Labour...

- They simply do not understand the plight of British farmers and fishermen: if they did, they would not have allowed today's disastrous situation to develop. Their record in Government shows that they have no conception of the kind of policies that are needed to promote a thriving rural economy.
- Labour MEPs fought tooth and nail to oppose the EU inquiry into the 2001 Foot and Mouth crisis; their chief concern has been to try and conceal the Government's blunders rather than to ensure that lessons are learned to make sure such a fiasco cannot happen again.

And the Liberal Democrats ...

- They are so uncritically committed to the European project that they tamely accept the status quo in the CAP and the CFP, despite the clear need for reform. A Labour Minister from Westminster and a Liberal Democrat Minister from Scotland signed up to the disastrous CFP deal which has seen 40 per cent of the UK whitefish fleet scrapped in the past 2 years.

Foot and Mouth

Following the devastating outbreak of Foot and Mouth Disease (FMD) in the UK in 2001, Conservatives campaigned successfully for a public inquiry committee at EU level, after the Labour Government refused widespread appeals to allow a UK inquiry. Despite fierce opposition from the Labour Government and Labour MEPs, this Conservative initiative led to a full, year-long, public investigation into the outbreak involving MEPs from all affected countries and all political parties. The British people had a right to know the truth about what really happened and to have confidence that steps had been taken to prevent any recurrence.

The inquiry which we secured for Britain produced a damning report on the Government's failure during the crisis. It criticised the lack of contingency planning, condemned the treatment of farmers, and set out clear proposals to deal with any future outbreak. These proposals and recommendations now form the basis of a draft EU directive that will determine the way any such crisis would be handled in future. The Conservative-inspired report was overwhelmingly approved by the European Parliament in May 2003.

New Threats from the EU Constitution

- The Intergovernmental Conference offered a major opportunity for CAP and CFP reform. The Government's failure to try to achieve it is a shameful indictment of its attitude to farmers and fishermen.



ASYLUM, IMMIGRATION AND BORDER CONTROL

Britain has an enviable record of racial integration. Over centuries, this country has successfully absorbed many immigrant communities. They have held on to their traditions and culture while at the same time embracing Britain's and playing a full role in our national life. But Labour's complete loss of control over the immigration and asylum system threatens this legacy.

Asylum and immigration are international issues. Conservatives strongly support close co-operation between EU Member States where it can play an effective part. The UK must maintain its own border controls, but at the same time the external borders of the EU must be properly policed in the interests of the EU as a whole.

We reject measures to harmonise immigration, asylum and border control policies. There can be no one-size-fits-all model. The UK must retain control over its own borders and the power to negotiate agreements with other countries on a bilateral basis. Conservatives will put Britain first by using European co-operation to make our policies on asylum, immigration and border control more effective, but we will not let these vital decisions become a matter for Brussels to decide.

Effective co-operation between Member States...

- Bilateral readmission agreements worked under the last Conservative Government. Labour abandoned them, and the 'Sangatte' fiasco was the result.
- Inter-governmental co-operation on border control is essential, especially in view of the extension of the EU's external borders following enlargement.

...and national control, not a single EU approach...

- We will defend Britain's opt-out from the Schengen agreement on removing borders within the EU.
- We will insist on the retention of Britain's veto over all proposals for EU laws on asylum, immigration and border control.
- We reject the idea of a common EU border patrol force.

As for Labour...

- It tries to sabotage serious and responsible debate on asylum and immigration because it has lost control of the system. Labour's one solution is to transfer responsibility to the EU.
- The Labour Government accepts that asylum and immigration should pass under the control of the EU. This represents an abdication of our national interests and could lead to harmonisation for the sake of it.

And the Liberal Democrats...

- They offer no alternative to Labour. Indeed, they want to set up more EU quangos to take control of asylum and immigration policies. Liberal Democrat MEPs have opposed restrictions on asylum seekers entering the EU.

New Threats from the EU Constitution

- National vetoes would be abolished over the main aspects of asylum and immigration policy.
- An EU-controlled border guard has been proposed.
- Our power to reach effective bilateral agreements over asylum and immigration matters would be undermined.



FIGHTING INTERNATIONAL CRIME

Greater co-operation is needed between the police and courts of the various EU Member States – and those in countries outside the EU – to step up the fight against international crime. At the same time agreed joint measures must respect national legal practice, with policing and criminal law remaining under national control. Different countries have their own long-standing traditions of justice and policing which are at the heart of a nation's sense of community and identity.

European governments must work closely together to tackle all types of international crime: large-scale fraud, terrorism, and trafficking in drugs and in human beings. But this does not mean all existing legislation should be retained or that laws should be harmonised. Too often, bad laws have been passed under the guise of the fight against crime whose real objective has been further damaging harmonisation – the European Arrest Warrant for example. Rather than harmonising laws, the EU should work to promote practical measures to combat crime and the mutual recognition of criminal laws.

More needs to be done at EU level to tackle trafficking in drugs and in human beings. They need to be higher up the EU agenda – with much closer liaison between all the government agencies involved. With the enlargement of the EU, these issues have become even more urgent. We propose that a Commissioner should be given sole responsibility for co-ordinating the fight against drugs and human trafficking at the European level. Conservatives will put Britain first by working with our European partners to make all of us safer, but we will not sign up to a criminal code made in Brussels.

Co-operation to fight international crime...

- Conservatives want new effective joint measures to be developed in the fight against international crime.

- We believe that the fight against drugs and human trafficking must be given higher priority, backed up by publicity – with closer intergovernmental co-operation as the key to progress.
- We back closer co-operation to combat, in particular, terrorist financing, terrorist support systems and propaganda networks and to tighten export controls on technologies that would help terrorists.
- We believe that Joint Investigation Teams between two or more national police forces are a model for the development of successful practical measures across Europe.
- The EU ombudsman and national ombudsmen must work closely together to help citizens cope with legal issues in other Member States.

...but no move to an EU-controlled police force or judicial system...

- We will fight so-called 'institution creep' – like the creation of a European Public Prosecutor or turning Europol into an EU police force.
- EU laws must be subject to national vetoes – because they must respect civil liberties and national legal traditions. National parliaments must be fully consulted.
- We will be vigilant in ensuring the fight against international crime is not used as a pretext for damaging harmonisation.
- We recognise that Europol has an important role to play, but it must be fully and democratically accountable, operating in a transparent way.



As for Labour...

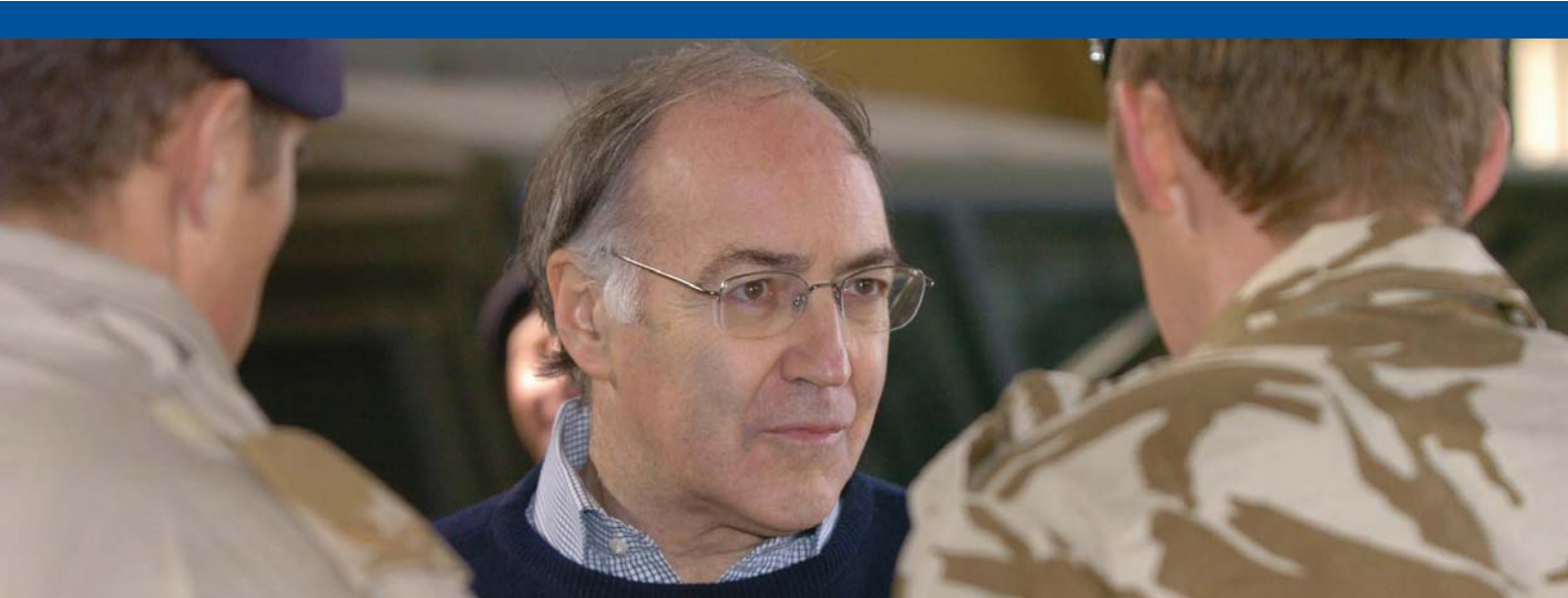
- They have now agreed in principle to extend the EU's role into criminal law matters – in sentencing, trial procedure and even defining certain crimes.
- Labour MEPs have supported the creation of a European Public Prosecutor, which would dramatically extend the EU's role in criminal law and policing, allowing Brussels to conduct prosecutions for itself, instead of national authorities enforcing the law.

And the Liberal Democrats...

- They ape Labour policy: they fully support the extension of the EU's role in criminal law matters while abandoning national vetoes.

New Threats from the EU Constitution:

- For the first time the EU would be able to make laws on criminal procedure and on the definition of a crime – without national vetoes.



FOREIGN AFFAIRS AND DEFENCE

It is imperative that foreign affairs and defence remain firmly under national control – so that we can safeguard vital national interests.

Conservatives welcome closer co-operation in areas where EU governments can work together in their mutual interests. But a single EU foreign policy is wholly unacceptable. It would undermine our sovereign independence and produce a clash with national interests – so it would be unworkable as well as wrong in principle. A joint EU approach can succeed in some limited areas, but the lesson of Iraq clearly is that a single EU foreign policy is illusory. Even where agreed EU action has taken place – as towards Zimbabwe and Burma – it has lacked the political will necessary to make it really effective.

NATO must remain the cornerstone of our defence and security policy. European defence initiatives must be carried out under the aegis of NATO to prevent duplication of effort and disagreement amongst our Allies. And through NATO, more effective military contributions and greater capability can be obtained from other European countries.

The EU is one of the most significant players in humanitarian aid and development policy. Yet despite recent reform, major failings remain in the management and effectiveness of the EU's overseas aid budget and the programmes it funds. By contrast, Britain runs a highly effective development policy. This makes it hard to justify the continued routing of much of our overseas aid through the EU.

Conservatives will put Britain first by working with our partners to make Europe and the world more secure, but we will not support an agenda that will lead to a Brussels-controlled foreign policy and a European army.

Co-operation in defence and foreign affairs

- We will insist that European defence initiatives are only carried out within the framework of NATO. We oppose separate EU defence structures which would waste scarce resources and capabilities, produce duplication of effort and create divisions among allies.
- Where the interests of European countries converge sufficiently to produce agreement, we will back a joint EU policy – but our national veto must remain over EU Common Foreign Policy activities and proposals.
- We will be in the forefront of efforts to improve relations with the US at all levels. Our vision is a fully-fledged transatlantic market place by 2015.
- We believe that the operational effectiveness of the UN must be improved – with Britain retaining her own seat on the UN Security Council, and other international bodies. These rights are not to be ceded to the EU.
- We want research and procurement to be co-ordinated more effectively – along with effective inter-operability of military equipment among European, US, and other allies.

Reforming Overseas Aid

- We want to take increasing control over our contribution to the EU's overseas aid budgets. Close co-operation among EU Member States should promote best practice and avoid duplication of effort.
- Aid money currently disbursed through the European Development Fund should be brought within the overall EU budget to increase democratic scrutiny, but we will oppose any consequent attempt to move the money's focus away from poverty reduction.

- Good governance, the rule of law and respect for human rights must be central objectives in our relations with developing countries.

As for Labour...

- They have supported the creation of an EU Foreign Minister – under some circumstances allowed to take a seat on the UN Security Council – and promoted a 'unified European foreign policy', which implies the end of an independent British foreign policy.
- Labour has shown that it cannot be trusted to safeguard vital defence interests. They have reversed the policy of all previous British governments and backed the creation of an EU defence force independent of NATO. Their approach threatens the defence partnership between Europe and America and could lead to a 'European army'.

And the Liberal Democrats...

- The Liberal Democrats want to go further and faster than Labour in developing a Common European Defence and Foreign Policy. They have called for the abolition of Britain's veto on EU foreign policy and actively supported plans to give up Britain's seat at the UN Security Council so that the EU can be represented. They want EU officials to draw up and oversee foreign policy on behalf of the UK.

New Threats from the EU Constitution:

- National vetoes in foreign policy would be weakened. An EU Foreign Minister, backed by an EU diplomatic service and answerable to EU institutions, would advance EU rather than British interests.

- There would be duplication of effort between NATO and EU defence – a recipe for muddle and failure. For example, the Constitution includes an EU 'mutual defence' clause, something that is currently the sole responsibility of NATO.

- The Constitution would pave the way for the EU to take Britain's seat at the UN Security Council.



THE EUROPEAN PARLIAMENT

The last ten years have seen a dramatic increase in the powers of the European Parliament. But the peoples of Europe have been voting in elections for that Parliament in diminishing numbers. That is because they have not been convinced that the EU is working steadily and effectively in their interests. The Parliament itself must accept some of the responsibility for this state of affairs.

The European Parliament must now be reformed in two fundamental respects in order to enable it to do the job that the peoples of Europe want. First, the Parliament must stop acting as an engine of ever-growing EU regulation. Conservatives want to cut back regulation, not promote it. Proposed new EU laws must be fully justified and must pass rigorous, independent cost/benefit tests. The Parliament should force the European Commission to withdraw legislative proposals that are unnecessary, impractical or unduly costly. That would allow more time for better scrutiny of proposals that are worthwhile. And national parliaments should be given the power to block EU initiatives where action at national level is what is required.

Second, the European Parliament must provide better value for money. There must be an end to disruptive shuttling between Brussels and Strasbourg, at a cost of £120 million per year, a wasteful state of affairs conceded by Labour. The Parliament's committee structure must be reformed so that the other EU institutions – particularly the European Commission – can be held effectively to account. The EU Parliament is a body which should concentrate above all on two things: accountability over how the EU budget is spent and the scrutiny of EU laws, confining them to their proper spheres. Conservatives will put Britain first by ensuring that British taxpayers get value for money and by giving British voters more control over what happens in Brussels.

The European Parliament needs improved scrutiny powers...

- It must have the right to summon and cross-examine all EU officials – and the power to dismiss individual Commissioners if they are found to be guilty of wrong-doing or incompetence.
- It must have the unequivocal right to examine as it sees fit any document necessary and relevant to its enquiries.

...to make it more focused and effective...

- A new and powerful committee on deregulation and competitiveness should be set up to ensure that all new proposals from the European Commission meet a genuine need and have been subject to rigorous independent cost/benefit analyses.
- Individual citizens and organisations should have the right to petition the Parliament for the repeal of existing EU legislation that is not needed.
- The European Parliament's Women's Committee should be reconstituted as a far-reaching Opportunities Committee with responsibility for ensuring that the interests of older people, children, ethnic minorities and the disabled, as well as women, are taken fully into account in EU policies and legislation.
- Joint committees of MPs and MEPs should be set up to hold government ministers to account before and after EU negotiations, and to oversee the implementation of EU regulations.

...and provide better value for money...

- The European Parliament should stop travelling back and forth between Strasbourg and Brussels: the latter should become its permanent home.

- 
- The overall running costs of the European Parliament should be cut.
 - MEPs' pay and expenses must be reformed in line with three key principles: MEPs should be paid the same as MPs; MEPs should pay tax at the same rate as their constituents; and the reimbursement of MEPs' expenses must be fully transparent.

Gibraltar

In April 2001 the Government started secret negotiations with Spain to share sovereignty over Gibraltar, despite the fact that the people of Gibraltar are fiercely loyal to the Crown and have made it absolutely clear that they want to remain British.

In November 2002 the people of Gibraltar demonstrated their opposition to the negotiations by voting overwhelmingly in a referendum to remain British. But the previous Anglo-Spanish agreement in principle to share sovereignty is still on the table. We are totally opposed to that agreement in principle. Sovereignty shared is sovereignty surrendered. We will not surrender British sovereignty.

An incoming Conservative Government will not be bound by any agreement to surrender Gibraltar's sovereignty which has been reached without the consent of the people of Gibraltar. We will disown this Government's agreement in principle to share sovereignty with Spain.

We believe that Britain and Spain should now discuss those matters where agreement can be reached. They do not include the issue of sovereignty. They should be confined to such issues as better communications, transport links, improved trading relations and improved co-operation on infrastructure projects, for example improvements to Gibraltar's airport which will be of benefit to both Spain and Gibraltar.



Conservatives in the European Parliament

Conservative MEPs in the European Parliament have worked effectively with other centre-right parties to achieve our stated aims and goals. During the 1999-2004 Session we were allied members of the Group of the European People's Party and European Democrats (EPP-ED). It became increasingly clear, however, that there were substantial differences of view between the EPP and ED elements of the Group on constitutional and institutional issues. This called for a revised relationship with the EPP-ED.

We negotiated, and have secured, two very important changes to the Group's Statutes.

First, we have secured a change in the Statutes of the Group which will enable the ED element to promote and develop its own distinctive position on constitutional and institutional issues in relation to the future of Europe. This change enshrines that right for the first time.

Second, a post of ED Vice-Chairman will be reserved within the Presidency of the Group.

We have also secured the right of any Member of the European Parliament to apply to join either the EPP or ED elements of the Group. Centre-right parties, including our sister parties from Central and Eastern Europe, will now have the opportunity to sit with British Conservatives in the ED and follow our distinctive agenda.

When elected, every Conservative Member of the European Parliament will be committed to this position.

This agreement means that Conservative MEPs will remain allied members of the EPP-ED parliamentary group for the duration of the 2004-2009 legislature. It provides us with a powerful platform to promote our distinctive vision of Europe, while at the same time allowing us to work constructively with all parties of the European centre-right against the threat posed by the Left in the European Parliament.

